

Hair in Every Texture

The curl and coil spectrum, porosity, and the textured hair every curriculum before this one forgot

Learning Objectives

- Describe the curl pattern spectrum from straight to coily, and explain why it is a spectrum, not a hierarchy
- Test and explain a client's hair porosity, and why it changes how product behaves on the strand
- Distinguish hair density from hair thickness, and explain why the two are so often confused
- Name the gap in global beauty education this module exists to close, and describe why closing it matters at Amber

Texture, not hierarchy

For most of the modern beauty industry's history, "manageable" hair meant one thing: straight, or loosely waved. Curricula were built around it, product lines were formulated for it, and every other texture was treated as a deviation to be corrected rather than a pattern to be understood. This module exists to correct that inheritance. Texture is not a scale from difficult to easy. It is a spectrum of genuinely different structures, each with its own needs, and a practitioner trained on only one end of that spectrum is only half-trained.

There is no such thing as good hair or bad hair — only hair you understand, and hair you do not yet.

Why curl happens at all

Curl pattern is determined by the shape of the follicle beneath the scalp, not by anything happening to the visible strand. A round follicle produces a straight strand. An oval follicle

produces a wave or curl. A follicle that is flat and asymmetric, curved beneath the skin like a shepherd's hook, produces a coil — and the more curved the follicle, the tighter the coil above it. This single structural fact explains almost everything you will observe about how different textures behave, absorb product, and respond to styling.

The curl spectrum, in practice

The classification system most widely used in the industry today — Types 1 through 4, with sub-categories A, B, and C for wave and curl diameter — was popularised as a commercial tool, and it deserves a practitioner's healthy scepticism: it was never a clinical system, and hair on a single head very often carries three or four types at once. Used carefully, though, it remains a useful shared vocabulary.

- **Type 1 — straight.** No visible curl pattern; the strand reflects light easily, which is why straight hair often appears shinier even at equal health.
- **Type 2 — wavy (A–C).** An S-shaped bend, ranging from a loose beach wave to a defined, springy wave.
- **Type 3 — curly (A–C).** Well-defined ringlets, from a loose curl the width of a piece of chalk to a tight corkscrew curl.
- **Type 4 — coily (A–C).** A tight, dense pattern often shaped like a zigzag or a very small spring; at its tightest (4C), the pattern may show minimal visible definition when dry and shrink dramatically from its true length.

Type 4 hair is the texture most consistently absent from mainstream training, despite being the texture of a very large share of the world's population — including large communities across South India and among India's tribal and diaspora populations. It is also, structurally, the most fragile texture: every bend in the strand is a point of mechanical stress, which is why coily hair, though it looks resilient, breaks more easily than any other type and demands the gentlest possible handling. You will study this principle fully in Module Six.

◆ Figure 2.1 · The Curl Pattern Spectrum



Curl diameter narrows and bend frequency increases from left to right — a spectrum of structure, not a ladder of difficulty.

Porosity: the cuticle's gatekeeping

Where curl pattern is about shape, porosity is about the cuticle's ability to absorb and hold moisture — and it matters just as much to how you treat a client's hair.

- **Low porosity** — cuticle scales lie flat and tight. Moisture and product struggle to penetrate, and product often sits on the surface. Lighter, water-based formulas and gentle heat help open the cuticle.
- **Normal porosity** — cuticle scales are moderately loose, absorbing and retaining moisture well. The easiest texture to work with, and the benchmark against which the other two are measured.
- **High porosity** — cuticle scales are raised or damaged, often from chemical services, heat, or sun exposure. Moisture enters quickly but escapes just as fast, leaving hair prone to frizz and dryness. Protein-rich treatments and sealing oils help close the cuticle back down.

A simple client-facing test: drop a clean strand of shed hair into a glass of room-temperature water. Low-porosity hair floats for several minutes; high-porosity hair sinks quickly. It is imperfect, but it is an honest, teachable moment for a client who has never thought about her hair this way before.

Density and thickness are not the same word

Density describes how many strands grow per square inch of scalp — how much hair a client has. Thickness (or diameter) describes how wide each individual strand is — coarse, medium, or fine. A client can have low density and thick, coarse individual strands, or high density and

fine ones. Confusing the two leads to prescribing the wrong products entirely: a client with fine, high-density hair needs volume without weight; a client with coarse, low-density hair needs the opposite. You will return to prescribing by these distinctions fully in Module Thirteen.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

3

[object Object]

Practical Activity · The Texture Map

Working with a partner or a mirror, identify your own (or a model's) curl type, porosity, density, and thickness using the tests taught in this module. Record all four, then write two sentences on how each would change your product and technique choices. **Keep this record — it becomes the first entry in your consultation practice in Module Ten.**